What is the Spirit Saying?

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Surely the Lord God does nothing, without revealing his secret to his servants the prophets. The lion has roared; who will not fear? The Lord God has spoken; who can but prophesy? (Amos 3:78)

This passage from the prophet Amos reveals an important truth about how God deals with his people. God speaks to his people. He reveals his secrets and makes known his plans before he acts. To make known his plans, he chooses prophets from among his people to speak on his behalf. These prophets are given a glimpse, a kind of sneak preview of the coming action of God. Throughout the scriptures God sends his prophets to awaken his people, to capture their attention and to lead them to turn their hearts toward God. The prophet prepares God's people to recognize and respond to God's action in their midst. Though the prophet's message may vary, ranging from warning to consolation, the prophet himself stands as a sign to all the people that God is not far off, that he knows the condition of his people, and that he, the Lord of history, desires to bring his plans for them to fulfillment.

In our day God is once again raising up prophets to speak to his people. We are standing at a historic moment, the close of an age. It is a time of transition; its significance transcends a mere turning of the clock or the flip of the calendar. I believe it is a time replete with spiritual significance, a time

of opportunity, in which God is calling out to his people through his servants the prophets. Like the roar of a great lion, God's word has begun to thunder forth with an ever increasing intensity and clarity. He is stirring his bride, the Church, from her present slumber. He stands ready to take her by the hand and to lead her through the threshold of the next millennium.

The question before us is whether we will hear his word and respond to it. Will we take it seriously? Will we give it the place in our lives that it deserves or will we allow it to be silenced by the multitude of voices which clamor for our attention and our time? Like many in Jesus' time, will we, too, miss the time of his visitation? Will we fail to "interpret the signs of the times" and, as a result, miss the unfolding of God's purposes in our lives? *"He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches." (Revelation 2:11)*

What is the Spirit saying to the Church? Where are the signs that point to the Lord's word in our day? How can I respond to that word? These are the kinds of questions I want to address in this short booklet. My hope is that through this booklet you may begin to see more clearly the many and manifold ways in which God is calling out to his people in our day. My prayer is that we not only hear his word, but that we have the courage to respond to it with the obedience and commitment that it deserves.

The Condition of the World Today

At the beginning of this century, Pope Leo

XIII received a vision which I believe, provides an important key to understanding the meaning of the Spirit's action as it unfolds in these last days of the 20th century. By way of summary, I will quote from Ralph Martin's account of Pope Leo XIII's vision as it appears in his recent book, *The Catholic Church at the End of An Age: What is the Spirit Saying?*:

> *While concluding a liturgical celebration in the last part of the nineteenth century in the Vatican, Leo XIII suddenly stopped and looked transfixed. He later recounted to his close collaborators what he had experienced. He had been allowed by the Lord to overhear a conversation between Satan and the Lord. The conversation was reminiscent of the conversation that Satan and the Lord had regarding the testing of Job in the Book of Job. Satan declared that if he had enough time and enough power he would be able to destroy the Church. God gave permission to Satan to take the bulk of the twentieth century as a time in which he would be allowed specially to test and tempt the Church, but after that his power would be limited again. It was as a result of this vision that Leo XIII asked that a special prayer to St. Michael the Archangel be said after every Mass throughout the world.* [1]

As we look back on the past one hundred years, who could fail to see the hand of the evil one pressing down on the Church and the world with a constant and unrelenting force? Even though this century has witnessed unprecedented advance in almost every conceivable field of endeavor, the

shadow of death and the mystery of evil seem to hang over it like a dark, black cloud. Neither our affluence, our military power, nor our technological genius have been able to stop our gradual slide into what Pope John Paul II has called *"a veritable culture of death."*[2]

Consider what this century has produced. It began with World War I and the rise of Communism in Russia. How was this atheistic, anti-Christian system, founded on the denial of God and all metaphysical reality, able to spread its errors over a third of the world in just a half a century? Where did it come from and how many tens of millions of people were killed by this "political system?"

The Holocaust is just one historical event symbolic of the mysterious evil which seemed to sweep over this century in waves. How could such unspeakable evil come to the Jewish people at the hands of educated, civilized people? What forces were at work driving the black-booted stormtroopers of Nazi Germany and their twisted doctrine of Aryan superiority?

For fifty years the world has heard the cry of the Jewish people, "Never again!" It is a cry that has fallen on deaf ears, for we find ourselves once again, at the close of this century, with the frightening images of concentration camps and mass graves in the heart of Europe. Yet Bosnia is not alone: the same savagery and tribal warfare has been repeated in Angola, Liberia, Sri Lanka and Rwanda. Just two years ago *Time* Magazine's Nancy Gibbs described the "killing frenzy" which took place in Rwanda, where an estimated 500,000 men, women and children had been killed in the tribal conflict between

the ruling Hutu tribe and the rebel Tutsi tribe.[3] Her description of the Hutu death squads was particularly chilling:

> *These are young men in street clothes, armed with anything from a screwdriver to an Uzi to a machete, a dull gleam in their eyes and a whistle around their neck. If one spotted a Tutsi family emerging from hiding and trying to flee, he blew his whistle, and his comrades sealed off any escape. "If you look in their eyes," says Daniel Bellamy of the U.N. High Commission for Refugees, who has encountered these killers at numerous roadblocks in the capital, "There is something there that is not in the eyes of normal people."* [4]

She goes on to describe the brutal nature of the murders perpetrated by these death squads:

> *Blood flowed down the aisles of churches where many sought refuge; five priests and 12 women hiding out in a Jesuit center were slaughtered. A Red Cross ambulance was stopped at a checkpoint, the six wounded patients dragged out and bayoneted to death. Toddlers lay sliced in half, and mothers with babies strapped to their backs sprawled dead on the streets of Kigali. The fighting was hand to hand, intimate and unspeakable, a kind of bloodlust that left those who managed to escape it hollow eyed and mute.*[5]

The fighting in Rwanda was so overwhelming it left one missionary to conclude: *"There are no devils left in Hell, they are all in Rwanda."* [6]

Along with the many wars and tribal conflicts, this century has witnessed an ever intensifying assault on the unborn. As the century has progressed in time, so has the strategic and unrelenting battle against these innocents. Three quarters of the way through this century the killing of the unborn was declared a fundamental right in the United States. Since that time an estimated 20 million children have been butchered on the altar of free choice in the exercise of this new, legal right. Why, in this century, has the merciless slaughter of the innocent suddenly become a fundamental human right?

There are many more signs that highlight the dramatic way in which the forces of darkness have been unleashed in our day. To name a few: the unprecedented breakdown of the family, the high divorce rate, the skyrocketing rate of violent crime among our youth, and the proliferation of sexually transmitted diseases. Bill Bennett, former secretary of the Department of Education, recently cited an alarming statistic:

> *Today, 30 percent of all births and 68 percent of black births are illegitimate. By the end of the decade, according to most reliable projections, 40 percent of all American births and 80 percent of minority births will occur out of wedlock.*[7]

It is difficult to read bad news. The temptation is to avoid a serious look at our actual condition because we fear there is no solution to these overwhelming problems. The attempt to put a positive spin on what we have faced in this century

can easily lead us to misread what has actually happened. The truth is we have been and still are living in the midst of a spiritual battle, a genuine struggle between the forces of darkness and light. The warfare and the casualties are real. In 1976, Pope John Paul II, then Cardinal Karol Wojtyla, identified the diabolic struggle we have endured this way:

> *We are now standing in the midst of the greatest historical confrontation humanity has gone through. I do not think that wide circles of the American society or wide circles of the Christian community realize this fully. We are now facing the final confrontation between the Church and the antiChurch, of the Gospel versus the antiGospel. This confrontation lies within the plans of divine Providence; it is a trial which the whole Church...must take up.*[8]

We have seen the vision articulated by Pope Leo XIII come to pass. We are currently living in the midst of a great trial, a deep, deep struggle. The attack is so unrelenting it seems the enemy has unleashed all his force on this century. At the heart of the battle has been the seductive temptation to find life and freedom apart from God. Cardinal Ratzinger described it this way:

> *The core temptation for man and of his fall is contained in this programmatic statement: "You will be like God (Genesis 3:5)." Like God: that means free of the law of the Creator, free of the laws of nature herself, absolute lord of one's own destiny. Man continually desires only one thing: to be his own creator and his*

own master. But what awaits us at the end of this road is certainly not Paradise.[9]

Haven't we seen this demand for radical, absolute autonomy in our day? Satan has preyed upon this deep desire and weakness in us to exalt ourselves above God. Our radical desire for freedom from God has culminated in the creation of what Pope John Paul II, the most significant prophetic voice of our age, called *"a veritable culture of death."*[10] Apart from God we become slaves to the power of sin and death. Without God, death becomes the greatest power over human life.

If we look closely, it is increasingly evident that death has become the solution to man's greatest problems. Death saves us from suffering and inconvenience; it is the way to insure our comfort and freedom. We are in the midst of a profound anti-evangelization, an inversion and perversion of the truth. Death is literally presented as life. Our society has accepted this lie, and, with all our genius, affluence and radical freedom, we have created a culture of death:

Humanity today offers us a truly alarming spectacle, if we consider not only how extensively attacks on life are spreading but also their unheard of numerical proportion, and the fact that they receive widespread and powerful support from a broad consensus on the part of society...The twentieth century will have been an era of massive attacks on life, an endless series of wars and a continual taking of innocent human life. False prophets and false

teachers have had the greatest success.[11]

The Church herself, the Bride of Christ, has felt the effects of this constant onslaught. At the end of this century of trial and temptation, she stands in a weakened state, buckling under the weight of the forces that press upon her. She is wounded, tired, and dazed by her ordeal. Many have abandoned the faith. She seems unable to capture the imagination of her contemporaries who seem indifferent to her message. It seems she is no match for the ever advancing pagan culture which surrounds her. Cardinal Ratzinger recently made the following observation:

> *Undoubtedly de-Christianization has reached levels that were unimaginable when the Council closed. Suffice to consider that in former Communist Germany today just over ten per cent of the population is baptized: we are witnessing paganism's incredible rate of progress and Christianity, which still seemed present 30 years ago, is disappearing from life and from public conscience.*[12]

In the words of Cardinal Hans Groer, of Vienna:

> *The Church has never had so many baptized and yet there have never been so many people who do not believe.*[13]

Fr. Benedict Groeschel, director of the Spiritual Life Office of the Archdiocese of New York, describes the present time in the history of the Church as follows:

> *The collapse of religious life, the death of*

vocations, the lowering of ecclesiastical discipline, particularly vis à vis false teaching and moral teaching, the general confusion, the apostasy of the Catholic universities, the loss of the sense of the divinity of Christ, all these conspire to make this the most difficult time in Catholic history.[14]

The effects of the spiritual conflict and trial the Church has undergone in this century are visible for all to see. The decline in church attendance throughout the Western world and the denial of basic morality are two telltale signs. One study in the United States showed that in 1963 only 13 percent of U.S. Catholics felt that premarital sex was permissible; in 1987 seventy one percent felt it was permissible.[15] One recent Gallup poll showed that only 30 percent of the Catholic faithful believe what the Church teaches on the presence of Jesus in the Eucharist.[16]

In Canada, only 39 percent attend church even on a monthly basis. Almost 91 percent approve of artificial birth control, 82 percent condone premarital sex, 55 percent condone homosexual activity, and only 20 percent support the Church's teaching on abortion.[17]

Fr. Yves Congar described the situation in France this way:

It is dramatic in many respects. There is no need to talk about it because the statistics say it all. Fourteen percent of adults and only seven percent of young people go to church... And then there is a desperate lack of priests.

In the parish where I grew up only one Mass every two months is celebrated...Inevitably the young are returning to paganism. There is no more religious practice. Yes, the situation is dramatic.[18]

Indeed the situation in which we now stand is dramatic. We, the Church, the Body of Christ, must acknowledge the crisis we have undergone, the inroads the enemy has made into the Church, and allow it to humble us. But lest we fall prey to despair, we must recognize that God has permitted the Church to undergo this trial by fire. We have been seriously tested and in many ways we have been found wanting. He has guided our way with a severe mercy. He is allowing us to come to grips with the actual condition of our hearts, to see the depth of our pride and the devastating reality of its effect, so that we might repent and turn back to him:

If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face, and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven, and will forgive their sin and I will heal their land. (2 Chronicles 7:14)

Submit yourself therefore to God. Resist the devil and he will flee from you. Draw near to God and he will draw near to you...Humble yourselves before the Lord and he will exalt you. (James 4:7,10)

I believe that in our desperate, humbled condition the Lord is beginning to unfold the next phase of his plan for the Church and for the world.

I believe that the particular period of testing and trial which Pope Leo XIII spoke about is coming to an end. Despite the present weak condition of the Church, the tide has begun to turn. As one pastor put it recently, *"I hear the supernatural sound of the army of the Lord in my Spirit."* [19] As I travel, whether in the United States, Eastern Europe, Africa or Canada, I have met large numbers of people who have begun to sense the same thing. The Lord is mounting a counter offensive. The hold of the enemy is weakening. In his book, *The Final Hour*, author Michael H. Brown recounts a message Mary had given to Mirjana, one of the visionaries at Medjugore, in which Mary speaks in similar terms:

> *Excuse me for this, but you must know that Satan exists...this century is under the power of the devil, but when the secrets I have confided to you have been fulfilled, his power will be destroyed. Even now he is beginning to lose his power.* [20]

A Prophetic Voice

I began this short booklet with a passage from the prophet Amos where he proclaims that the Lord begins his work by first revealing his plans to his servants the prophets. In our day he has raised up Pope John Paul II, in the words of Catherine of Sienna, to *"utter a roar over the body of Holy Church, lusty enough to wake up the children lying asleep within."* He is speaking with the boldness and the clarity of a prophet. I believe the Lord has anointed him to rally the Church to what the Spirit is saying and to lead the Church through the threshold

of the next millennium. Consider these words:

> *As the third millennium of the redemption draws near, God is preparing a great springtime for Christianity, and we already see the first signs...*[21]
>
> *I see the dawning of a new missionary age, which will become a radiant day bearing an abundant harvest, if all Christians...respond with generosity and holiness to the calls and challenges of our age...*[22]
>
> *God is opening before the Church the horizons of a humanity more fully prepared for the sowing of the Gospel. I sense the moment has come to commit all the Church's energies to a new evangelization...no believer in Christ, no institution of the Church can avoid this supreme duty: to proclaim Christ to all people.*[23]
>
> *The Spirit of God seems to be stirring up in the Christian people the original missionary zeal, when the faith was able to spread rapidly because of the heroic witness of every baptized person.*[24]

As I contemplate his words, I am reminded of John the Baptist, whom the Holy Spirit had chosen to "prepare the way of the Lord." St. John knew that God's plan was unfolding, and that the time had come to prepare God's people to receive God's action in their midst. I believe that Pope John Paul II, in an analogous way, is preparing God's people to receive a coming action of God in our day. Consider his words, "God is preparing a great springtime,"

and "God is opening ...the horizons of a humanity" and "The Spirit of God seems to be stirring..." Pope John Paul II is not talking about what he, as the Vicar of Christ, is doing to prepare the Church; he is telling us what God himself has begun to do. He is interpreting for us what the Spirit is saying so that we can respond appropriately.

But just as in Jesus' time, it is possible for us to miss the time of God's visitation. In fact, the Holy Father normally speaks about what is unfolding in conditional terms. That is, he reminds us that the full flowering of God's plan for our age depends in part on our response to the Spirit's initiative. He says, *"...the new springtime of Christian life...will be revealed by the Great Jubilee, if Christians are docile to the action of the Holy Spirit."* [25]

We need to listen to what the Spirit is saying and respond wholeheartedly. Each one of us must recognize that God is speaking to us personally, that he is bidding us to join him in bringing about this time of grace for the Church and for the world.

Our Response

How can we prepare for this coming action of God? The first step is to repent, to acknowledge our sin and to turn back to God:

> *She (the Church) cannot cross the threshold of the new millennium without encouraging her children to purify themselves, through repentance, of past errors and instances of infidelity, inconsistency, and slowness to act.*[26]

The Holy Father is leading the way for the Church through his own example. Despite strong opposition from some of his own advisors, he has begun to repent openly for the sins of the Church. For example, on a recent trip to Africa he acknowledged and asked forgiveness for the Church's involvement in the slave trade. Like John Paul II, we also must humbly posture ourselves in order to receive the coming grace of the Spirit. Ralph Martin often recounts how he was deeply moved the first time he heard that the Holy Father was taking this bold and courageous step because repentance often precedes revival.

The next step of preparation is to listen to what the Spirit is saying and to be docile to the Spirit's action in our own lives. Again, in the words of Pope John Paul II:

> *The Church cannot prepare for the new millennium "in any other way than in the Holy Spirit. What was accomplished by the power of the Holy Spirit 'in the fullness of time' can only through the Spirit's power now emerge from the memory of the Church."* [27]

Do you hear what he is saying? What most needs to happen is that we, the Church, need to once again grasp and claim the truth of what God has done for us in Christ Jesus. In the fullness of time, God sent forth his Son into the world to become our Savior and Lord. It's that basic truth, the kerygma, the living awareness that Jesus is Lord, that must be reawakened in the Church. The Church lives by a faith vision of what God has done for us in Christ. It is the source of our life:

For what we preach is not ourselves, but Jesus Christ as Lord, with ourselves as your servants for Jesus' sake. For it is the God who said, "Let light shine out of darkness," who has shown in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God which shines on the face of Christ. (2 Corinthians 4:56)

For too many in the Church today, Jesus is no more than a great moral teacher, a prophetic figure who teaches us how to be good people. With this limited and distorted view of Christ, Christianity is reduced to a morality, a way of living out the law. This notion significantly weakens the Church and completely misses the heart of who Jesus really is. Jesus is not just a good moral teacher. In the words of St. Paul, Christianity is "a new creation"(Galatians 6:15) Jesus brought us new life that never ends! When Jesus was raised from the dead, a new type of existence was born in him. True hope had finally come, and death no longer had the last word:

Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! By his great mercy we have been born anew to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, and to an inheritance which is imperishable, undefiled and unfading, kept in heaven for you...(1 Peter 1:3)

It is not enough for us to possess true facts about Jesus. If we are to live with the dynamism and the power of a disciple of Christ, we must know Jesus the person. We must come to see that there is no one like him. He is Lord. He is God. All that is beautiful, good, and true comes from him. All time, all creation,

all that exists belongs to him. Our past, present and future are in his hands. Only the Holy Spirit can bring this faith vision of Jesus alive in our hearts. The Holy Father repeats this theme continually:

> *Be open to Christ, welcome the Spirit, so that a new Pentecost can take place in every community! A new humanity, a joyful one, will arise from your midst; you will again experience the saving power of the Lord and 'what was spoken to you by the Lord' will be fulfilled.*[28]

The Great Jubilee Year 2000

This theme is at the heart of the Holy Father's vision for the Great Jubilee Year 2000. The Church is preparing for a fresh proclamation of the Gospel. In choosing the Jubilee theme, I believe the Holy Father has captured the meaning of what the Spirit is saying in our time. The concept of the Jubilee is taken from the Old Testament. God commanded his people to set aside every seventh year as a year of rest. It was a year of God's favor, a sabbatical year, when debts were canceled, prisoners set free, and even the land lay fallow: *For six years sow your fields, and for six years prune your vineyards and gather their crops. But in the seventh year the land is to have a sabbath rest, a sabbath to the Lord. (Leviticus 25:12)*

The Jubilee year occurred every fifty years and embodied the same themes of the sabbatical year but in a more complete and abundant way: *Count seven sabbaths seven times seven years...consecrate the fiftieth year and proclaim liberty throughout the*

land to all the inhabitants. It shall be a jubilee for you. (Leviticus 25:8, 11) The Jubilee was a period of great joy. It was a time of favor and great grace for God's people. Those who were in debt, those who were imprisoned and without hope, those who were poor and forgotten, all experienced freedom and provision at the hands of the Lord. This extraordinary and concrete expression of God's favor came for one reason: *the Lord's time of release had been proclaimed. (Deuteronomy 15:2)*

As we know, the Jubilee Year was a foreshadowing, an anticipation of the true freedom and favor which was to be revealed in Christ. Jesus alone fulfills the Jubilee by freeing the human race from its condition of slavery to the power of sin and death:

> *The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, for he has anointed me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim release to the captives and recovery of sight to the blind, to set at liberty those who are oppressed, to announce the year of the Lord's favor. (Luke 4:18-19).*

I believe we are entering into a "season of release" for the Church and the world. I sense that it is the Lord who is moving the Holy Father to declare the year 2000 as a year of Jubilee. Through him and through the growing number of signs in our time, the Lord is speaking to us; he is telling us he is about to act.

Perhaps the most significant sign is the growing number of Marian apparitions taking place around the world. Beginning at Fatima in 1917 and increasing right up to the present time, Jesus has sent Mary, the Queen of Prophets, to warn the Church, to help guide us through this difficult century and to prepare us for the unfolding of God's plan. At the heart of her message is a call to repentance, a passionate plea to the world to return to God. As we approach the close of this century, the number of reported apparitions has intensified.

The demise of Communism, which was intimately tied to Mary's prophetic role, was a sign in the natural realm of what is about to unfold in the supernatural. Consider what we all witnessed in that collapse. Almost overnight, a massive atheistic power which enslaved almost a third of the world for the most of this century fell, and the hundreds of millions of people who suffered under this diabolic regime were set free!

As we have seen, the Church and the world have been deeply wounded by the demonic assault waged throughout this century. The kingdom of darkness has established strongholds or "structures of sin" which have enslaved large portions of our society. Just as with the collapse of Communism, I believe the Lord is going to release multitudes of people from the enemy's grasp. Again, consider the words of the Holy Father:

God is opening before the Church the horizons of a humanity more fully prepared for the

sowing of the Gospel...[29]

The preparation has begun with God's own household. He has prepared the Church by allowing us to be humbled and purified, to be brought to our knees, so that we might turn to him and follow him in our weakened state. He has also touched the Church in this century with a fresh outpouring of the charisms of the Holy Spirit to equip us to preach the Gospel with signs, wonders and power. In ever increasing numbers the laity are coming forward under the anointing and conviction of the Holy Spirit, filled with a deep missionary zeal, ready to follow the Lord wherever he may lead. I have personally met hundreds of brothers and sisters over the past five years from all over the world who have experienced the Lord preparing them for this next phase of his action. Many of them are ready to sell all they have in order to make the Gospel known again in our day.

It is clear to me that the Lord is also speaking to us through various emerging movements. Promise Keepers provides an amazing example of the "season of release" that is unfolding all around us. Promise Keepers began less than ten years ago, with the purpose of calling men to be faithful to their promises to God, to their spouses and families, and to challenge them to live the Gospel with integrity. Led by former University of Colorado head football coach Bill McCartney, the movement began with the sober realization that many of the maladies of today's society, particularly the destructive consequences of broken families, are the result of men failing to keep their promises. The heart of the movement is men helping other men to face up to their failures,

to acknowledge their sin and to give their lives back to God.

One reason I see this movement as an important sign is that through it tens of thousands of men are finding freedom from the diabolic temptations which have enslaved so many men in our day. The Spirit of God is breaking the enemy's hold on them in areas of addictions to money, sex and power. Idols are being cast down, the proud are being humbled, and the wandering hearts of many fathers are being turned back to their children.

Another reason I believe the movement is a sign is the rapid pace with which it is spreading. At this time in history when so many churches stand empty, close to one million men gather in stadiums across the United States to respond to what the Lord is doing in their lives. The numbers are expected to increase in the coming year. All this is happening *"because the time of the Lord's release has been proclaimed." (Deuteronomy 15:2)*

Another sign for me is the work of Fr. Mathew Naikamparambil of Potta, India. Fr. Peter Coughlin, editor of *The Bread of Life* magazine, gave a brief account of the unfolding of God's plan in the life of Fr. Mathew:

> *On January 1, 1987, Fr. Mathew, who had a large counseling ministry, received a prophetic word in prayer which said: "It is not enough to counsel my people; feed them, proclaim the word, go and preach to my people." Acting on the word he received, Fr. Mathew gathered together the seventy five people he*

was counseling and healings began to take place and the retreat ministry began.[30]

From this auspicious start, Fr. Mathew and his team developed a basic week-long retreat, highlighted throughout by a simple preaching of the kerygma and ministering in the power of the Holy Spirit. The ministry has grown at a phenomenal rate. Last year anywhere between 5,000 and 12,000 retreatants attended each week. Every Saturday at an all day prayer meeting in Potta, an average of thirty to forty thousand people gather to intercede for world evangelization.[31] Archbishop Alan DeLastic, the Archbishop of Delhi, reported that over 60,000 non-Christians have made a residential retreat in Potta.[32]

Again, we can ask why such phenomenal growth? This ministry unfolded because Fr. Mathew was "docile to the action of the Holy Spirit" in his life. He heard God's word to him and acted upon it. This is a concrete example of the "new dawning" and the "new springtime" the Holy Father often describes. This vision of the Jubilee is not wishful thinking or human striving toward a more positive future. God is acting and, if we respond with docility, we will see the full flowering of his plan in our lives.

Another sign for me personally has been the Lord's action in Renewal Ministries over the past five years where we often feel as though we have been swept up into this mighty work of God in our day. Back in 1989 my wife Debbie and I had been leading a ministry for young adults in our community for a number of years. Although the work had been

exciting and challenging for both of us, I felt the Lord might be moving us onto other things.

During a meeting with other leaders in our community, we began to pray and I sensed the Lord saying, "I'm coming, I'm coming." Then the Lord began to speak to me through a series of visions. During one of the visions, I saw the Lord, who was sitting upon his throne, stand up and say, "I have risen from my throne and I am about to act. I have sent forth my Spirit to precede my coming. There will be a revelation of the Son of Man in your lifetime." I felt as though the Lord was showing me that the whole purpose of the outpouring of the Holy Spirit in this century was a preparation for what was about to unfold. The captain of the armies of heaven was gathering his troops and he was about to ride into battle.

This was the beginning of a whole new phase for me and for the work of Renewal Ministries. Within just a few months, four different Christian leaders on four different occasions said similar things: the Lord was about to launch us into a new phase of his work; he was going to begin sowing us into lands throughout the world; we were to be a small part of a very significant work of grace that was already unfolding throughout the Catholic Church; our response was to wait on the Lord, and to ready ourselves for what was about to unfold. All of these encounters were unsolicited. What was even more surprising was that each of the words came through Protestant pastors who felt the Lord had shown them that a mighty work of God was about to be released within the Catholic Church that would be

felt throughout the entire world!

Then, just a few months later, we received a request to go to Lithuania to lead a series of evangelistic rallies. We went to Lithuania not knowing what to expect. What we saw was a further confirmation of all we had been sensing. At one of the rallies, which took place on Pentecost Sunday, we were gathered in an old hockey arena. The arena was packed with about five thousand people. For most, if not all of these people, it was the first time they had gathered for a religious event in a public place. Just three years earlier a gathering of that kind would have been illegal. After the first talk, we gave those in attendance an opportunity to come forward to receive prayer. Prior to the meeting, the Bishop of the diocese told us not to be offended or put off if no one came forward to receive prayer since that sort of public expression of faith or display of emotion would be an entirely new thing for those attending. To our surprise, when we gave the call to come forward, almost the entire arena got up from their seats to come forward for prayer. As our team members prayed with them, some began to weep, others began to laugh and dance with joy. Many were baptized in the Holy Spirit that day, while others were set free from the oppression of evil spirits. One 23 year old man, who had been completely deaf in his right ear for three years as the result of an accident, was healed. Our team of thirty prayed over people for more than eight hours that day. This whole experience reminded me of the experience of the early Church: *"So Paul and Barnabas...spoke boldly for the Lord, who confirmed the message of his grace by enabling them to do miraculous signs*

and wonders." (Acts of the Apostles 14:3)

Out of that initial mission, the Lord has opened doors for people from Renewal Ministries to minister in Slovakia, Ukraine, Poland, Hungary, Albania, Uganda, and Ghana. In Eastern Europe we were privileged to witness thousands make their first public proclamation of faith and give their lives more fully to Jesus. More and more we have witnessed a marked increase in the presence of signs and wonders as we have ministered. There are many other ministries that have experienced this same increase in spiritual power. The prayer of Pope John Paul II is being heard in the heavens:

> *Renew the miracles of the early Christian communities in these years leading up to the Year 2000, so that contemporary humanity will believe in Christ, the one Savior of the world.*[33]

Another important sign is the continuation of the infusion of charisms that has been a mark of the Holy Spirit's work in this century. This "season of release" includes not only a work of the Spirit setting people free from the strongholds of the enemy, but it is also a time when many have begun to experience a fresh release of spiritual gifts in their lives equipping them to minister in the strength of the Lord. One example of this is the growing appreciation for the gift of intercession. Have you noticed how the practice of Adoration of the Blessed Sacrament seems to be making a comeback? All over the world people are being moved to intercede before the Blessed Sacrament, and many for long periods of time. In that, I believe we are witnessing the Holy

Spirit moving the Church to cry out to Jesus from her depths. She is preparing the way for the action of the Lord in our day. The Bride is turning her face toward her Bridegroom and she is saying, "Come, Lord Jesus!"

This is the heart of what the Spirit is saying in our day: "Jesus!" He is the only solution to the crisis of this age. Only he who "disarmed the principalities and powers" (Colossians 2:15) can free us from the stranglehold of this culture of death. Pope John Paul II has stated this plainly:

> *What will free us from these signs of death? Experience in the world today increasingly shows that ideologies are unable to defeat that evil which keeps people enslaved. Christ is the only one who can free us from this evil...It makes the task that the Church is facing more urgent: to rekindle in the heart of all the baptized the grace they received. 'I remind you', St. Paul wrote to Timothy, 'to stir into flame the gift of God that you have' (2 Timothy 1:6).*[34]

Only when we turn to him and receive his grace will we be able to effectively confront the powers of this age. The solutions to our problems begin with him. All the wisdom, power, courage and energy we need to turn back this tide is in Jesus. In fact, he has already given us what we need: "to each has been given a manifestation of the Spirit for the common good."(1 Corinthians 12:7) These powers, which for so many in the Church lay dormant and undiscovered, are meant to be placed at the service of the Lord's purposes in order to build up his Body,

the Church. I believe the Lord is coming to draw on this investment he has made in each of our lives. We must allow him to awaken in us the gifts he has given for the building of his kingdom.

The call is urgent. It is time to lay all that we have, our time, money, our gifts, indeed, all that we are, at the feet of Jesus. The time has come to "give to God what belongs to God." (Matthew 22:21) To him belongs our faith, our trust and wholehearted devotion. If we surrender to his call with docility of heart, we will see the full flowering of the "new springtime" in our day. He will give us apostles, prophets, teachers, miracle workers, defenders of the poor and the weak, more champions for the cause of life. Indeed, we will be granted an extraordinary privilege: through us, he will bring honor and glory to his name! It is for this reason that we have been made. ✠

Footnotes

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4. Nancy Gibbs, "Why? The Killing Fields of Rwanda," *Time Magazine*, May 16, 1994, p. 59.

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7. William J. Bennett, "Getting Used to Decadence: The Spirit of Democracy in America", The Heritage Lectures, 1993.

8. Cardinal Karol Wojtya reprinted in *The Wall Street Journal* (November 9, 1978).

9. Cardinal Joseph Ratzinger, *The Ratzinger Report*, (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press, 1985), p. 91.

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12. Andre Tornielli, "Interview with Cardinal Ratzinger: Testimonies in the Pagan Age", *30 Days*, no. 11, 1992, pp. 29-30.

13. Cardinal Hans Hermann Groer, "From Values to Reality", *30 Days*, no. 5, 1993, p. 60.

14. Fr. Benedict Groeschel, "Dialogue," *National Catholic Register*, February 20, 1994, p. 10.

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21. Pope John Paul II, *Redemptoris Missio (Mission of the Redeemer)*, sec. 1.

22. Ibid., sec. 92.

23. Ibid., sec. 3.

24. Pope John Paul II, Angelus Address of December 10, 1995.

25. Pope John Paul II, *Apostolic Letter Tertio Millenio Adveniente (On the Coming of the Third Millennium)*, sec. 19.

26. Ibid., sec. 33.

27. Ibid., sec. 44.

28. Pope John Paul II, "Address to Bishops of Latin America," *L'Osservatore Romano* (English language edition), October 21, 1992, p. 10, sec. 30.

29. Pope John Paul II, *Redemptoris Missio (Mission of the Redeemer)*, sec. 12

30. Peter Coughlin, *The Bread of Life*, March 1995, p. 30.

31. Ibid., p. 30.

32. Archbishop Alan De Lastic, from *Potta Ministry of World Evangelization Newsletter*.

33. Pope John Paul II, Angelus Address, June 29, 1995.

34. Pope John Paul II, "Address to Bishops of Latin America", *L'Osservatore Romano* (English language edition), October 21, 1992, p. 8, sec. 19.